

Chapter 34: Things He Doesn't Say First

Jenny tried not to ask.

That was her rule.

Simple.

Clean.

Unspoken.

But rules like that never stayed intact for long when someone like Austin was involved.

He arrived later than usual that day.

Alone again.

No Victoria.

No explanation.

Just him, stepping into the restaurant like nothing in the last few days had rearranged anything.

Jenny watched him approach the counter.

And immediately hated that her body reacted before her mind did.

"You're late," she said.

Austin looked at her.

"I had a meeting."

Of course he did.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"With Victoria?"

The question slipped out too fast.

Too sharp.

Too revealing.

Silence followed.

Not uncomfortable.

Just... intentional.

Austin didn't look surprised.

Which somehow made it worse.

"No," he said finally.

That was all.

Jenny nodded quickly.

"Okay."

But she didn't move away.

And neither did he.

Austin studied her for a moment.

"You asked about her before."

"I didn't," Jenny replied immediately.

"You did."

"I was just—"

"Curious," he finished again.

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"You keep doing that."

"Doing what?"

"Finishing my sentences."

A pause.

Then calmly—

"I'm listening carefully."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not the same thing."

"It is when you speak indirectly."

That made her pause.

"...I don't speak indirectly."

Austin looked at her.

"You do when you're uncomfortable."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because he was right.

And she hated that he was right.

She turned away slightly.

"I don't care about your meetings."

A lie.

Even she knew it.

Austin didn't react strongly.

He never did when she deflected.

Instead, he said quietly,

"Victoria was not part of the meeting."

Jenny glanced at him.

"Why are you telling me that?"

A pause.

Then—

"Because you're trying not to ask."

Jenny stiffened slightly.

"I'm not trying anything."

"You are," he said calmly.

Silence again.

This one longer.

He didn't rush her.

He rarely did.

And that made it worse.

Jenny exhaled.

"What was she to you?"

The question came out quieter than she expected.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

For once.

He looked away.

Just slightly.

Then back at her.

And said,

"My past."

That word hung in the air.

Heavy.

Not dramatic.

Just final.

Jenny frowned.

"That doesn't explain anything."

"It explains enough," he said.

She shook her head.

"No, it doesn't."

Austin didn't argue.

He just watched her.

Patient.

And that patience cracked something in her.

Because it felt like he was giving her the space to decide how much truth she could handle.

Jenny lowered her voice.

"Did you love her?"

The question came out before she could stop it.

And the moment it did, she regretted it.

Because it wasn't professional.

It wasn't neutral.

It was personal.

Too personal.

Austin didn't respond immediately.

The restaurant noise faded again.

Not because it stopped.

Because it stopped mattering.

Then he said quietly,

"Yes."

Simple.

Honest.

No hesitation.

Jenny felt her stomach tighten slightly.

She nodded.

"...Okay."

But Austin didn't stop there.

For the first time, he added,

"Not the way I understand love now."

That made her look up again.

"What does that mean?"

A pause.

Then softer—

"I thought love was something you fit into your life."

Jenny listened.

"But it wasn't," he continued.

"It was something that changed it."

Silence.

Jenny didn't speak.

Because she didn't know what to say to that.

Austin leaned slightly against the counter.

"Victoria and I didn't survive that change."

Jenny frowned.

"...Because of you?"

"Yes."

That honesty again.

No hiding.

No blaming others.

Just him.

Jenny swallowed.

"And now she's back because...?"

Austin shook his head.

"She wasn't back for me."

A pause.

"She came to close something she left open."

Jenny looked down.

"Closure again."

"Yes."

That word again.

Closure.

It was starting to feel like something that belonged in his world.

Not hers.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"So she's gone now?"

Austin nodded.

"Yes."

Jenny hesitated.

Then quietly—

"Does it still matter?"

A pause.

Longer this time.

Then he said,

"No."

Jenny looked up immediately.

That answer surprised her.

Austin met her eyes.

"It stopped mattering when I realized I was still here."

Silence.

That landed differently.

Not as reassurance.

Not as comfort.

As something more grounded.

Jenny didn't know why it unsettled her more than anything else.

So she changed direction again.

"I don't like surprises," she muttered.

Austin almost smiled.

Almost.

"I noticed."

Jenny sighed.

"You should have told me earlier."

"I didn't think it was important."

She narrowed her eyes.

"You brought her here."

"Yes."

"That seems important."

Austin nodded once.

"It was for her."

A pause.

Then—

"Not for us."

Jenny looked at him.

"...Us again."

Austin didn't hesitate.

"Yes."

That word.

Always returning.

Jenny turned slightly away.

"I need to work."

Austin stepped back.

"I'll sit."

She nodded.

But before he walked away, he added quietly,

"Nothing changed what I told you before."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because for the first time...

she wasn't sure what she believed anymore.

And that was new.

Dangerously new.